

Serial Position Effect

What is it?

The position of information in a list affects how well people remember it. Users recall the first and last items better than the ones in the middle.

History

First identified by psychologist Hermann Ebbinghaus in 1885 while studying human memory and recall patterns.

The Psychology Behind It

Two forces drive this effect:

Primacy anchors memory at the start.

Recency strengthens recall of the end point.

This is why ordering matters. Users naturally store what comes first and what comes last far more effectively than what appears in the middle.

Why It Matters

Missing key messages

Losing premium actions in the middle

Weaker recall impacts user decisions

How to Apply It

Place key info, CTAs, and value propositions at the top and bottom

Keep lists short and clean

Use recognisable cues to reduce memory effort

Support recall with comparison visuals or summaries

Theory in Action

E-commerce platforms highlight “best sellers” at the top of listings.

Restaurant menus often place premium items at both the beginning and end of menu lists.

Final Thought

Where information is placed matters just as much as what you say. Positioning strategically helps users remember what truly counts.

